

Crisis Policing in Toronto’s Neighbourhoods*

Mental Health Act apprehensions are more frequent where more residents rent
and more Indigenous people live, 2014–2025

Zarif Masud

October 8, 2026

Toronto police detained people under Ontario’s Mental Health Act about 11,000 times a year between 2014 and 2025, four times in five on an officer’s own judgement. Combining these 131,325 apprehensions with 2021 Census profiles of the city’s 158 neighbourhoods, we find that apprehension rates are about 16 per cent higher for each standard-deviation increase in the share of households that rent and about 21 per cent higher for each standard-deviation increase in the share of Indigenous residents, and both patterns hold outside the downtown core. Separate race-based data on 65,276 arrests in 2020–2021 show that Black and Indigenous people were arrested at about three times the White rate, and that people police flagged as mentally unstable were strip searched far more often, with the largest gap for Black people. Crisis policing in Toronto is concentrated in particular places and falls most heavily on particular groups, which bears on where the city’s new non-police crisis service is most needed.

1 Introduction

When someone in Toronto is in a mental health crisis, the people who arrive are usually police officers. Ontario’s *Mental Health Act* lets an officer detain a person and take them to hospital for a psychiatric assessment, a power known as an apprehension (Government of Ontario 1990). Police contact is a routine part of living with a mental disorder: in Canada about one in three people with a mental or substance use disorder had contact with police in a year (Boyce et al. 2015), and internationally about one in ten people with a mental disorder had police involved in their pathway to care (Livingston 2016). In Toronto these encounters have sometimes been fatal, which led to an independent review of how police respond to people in crisis (Iacobucci 2014) and, in 2022, to the Toronto Community Crisis Service, which sends mental health workers instead of police to some calls (City of Toronto 2023).

*Code and data are available at: <https://github.com/TheZarif/toronto-crisis-policing>.

This paper asks where in Toronto crisis policing is concentrated, and who it falls on. We use 131,325 Mental Health Act apprehensions recorded by the Toronto Police Service from 2014 to 2025 (Toronto Police Service 2026a), about 10,900 a year, and link them to 2021 Census characteristics of the city’s 158 neighbourhoods (City of Toronto 2026b, 2026c). Our estimand is the association between a neighbourhood’s characteristics and its apprehension rate per resident, holding the other characteristics and the year constant. Because the apprehension data does not record the race of the person detained, we add the Toronto Police Service’s race-based data on 65,276 arrests in 2020 and 2021 (Toronto Police Service 2026b), which records the race police perceived for each person arrested and whether they appeared to be in a mental health crisis.

Apprehension rates are higher where more households rent and where more Indigenous people live. A one-standard-deviation increase in renter share is associated with a rate about 16 per cent higher, and a one-standard-deviation increase in Indigenous share with a rate about 21 per cent higher. Both associations hold when the downtown core, where many apprehensions involve people who do not live there, is excluded. Neighbourhood poverty matters only through the downtown core, and Black population share and the City’s own designation of disadvantaged neighbourhoods add little once renting and Indigenous share are accounted for. At the individual level, Black and Indigenous people were arrested at about 3.1 and 2.8 times the White rate relative to their share of the population. People flagged by officers as mentally unstable were far more likely to be strip searched, and the increase was largest for Black people.

These findings matter for two reasons. First, they connect Toronto to an international literature showing that coercive psychiatric care is concentrated in deprived and racialized areas (Weich et al. 2017) and among Black patients (Anderson et al. 2014), which has not previously been examined with Toronto’s police data at the neighbourhood level. Second, they suggest where non-police crisis response would reach the most people. The remainder of the paper is structured as follows. Section 2 describes the data and how each measure was produced. Section 3 sets out the models, Section 4 presents the results, and Section 5 discusses what they mean, along with the paper’s limitations. The appendices give further detail on cleaning, model checks and the arrest data.

2 Data

2.1 Sources

We use four datasets, all downloaded and processed in Python (Python Software Foundation 2025) with polars (Vink et al. 2026), pandas (McKinney 2010), NumPy (Harris et al. 2020), GeoPandas (Jordahl et al. 2026) and Shapely (Gillies et al. 2025). Figures are made with plotnine (Kibirige et al. 2026), tables with Great Tables (Iannone and Chow 2026), models are fitted with statsmodels (Seabold and Perktold 2010), data tests use pytest (Krekel et al.

2026), and the paper is written in Quarto (Allaire et al. 2022). The workflow follows Alexander (2023).

1. **Mental Health Act Apprehensions** (Toronto Police Service 2026a), published by the Toronto Police Service on Open Data Toronto (City of Toronto 2026d): one row per apprehension from 2014 onward, with the date, the legal authority used, the person’s sex and age group, the type of place and the neighbourhood where it happened.
2. **Neighbourhoods** (City of Toronto 2026c): boundaries of the City’s 158 social-planning neighbourhoods.
3. **Neighbourhood Profiles** (City of Toronto 2026b): 2021 Census counts for each neighbourhood, from which we take population, household tenure, low income, visible minority and Indigenous identity, and the City’s 2020 neighbourhood designation (City of Toronto 2014).
4. **Race and Identity Based Data Collection: Arrests and Strip Searches** (Toronto Police Service 2026b): one row per person arrested or strip searched in 2020 and 2021, with the race the officer perceived, demographics, the offence category, behaviour recorded at arrest, and whether the person was booked and strip searched. The copy on Open Data Toronto stops at 32,000 rows, so we download the full 65,276 rows from the Toronto Police Service’s own source.

2.2 Measurement

An apprehension enters the data through a chain of decisions. Someone, often a family member, bystander or the person themselves, calls 9-1-1 about a person who seems to be in crisis. Police attend. If the officer believes the person is acting in a disorderly way and is likely to seriously harm themselves or someone else, or cannot care for themselves, the officer can detain them under Section 17 of the *Mental Health Act* and take them to hospital (Government of Ontario 1990). Police also carry out apprehensions that someone else has authorized: a physician’s application for assessment (Section 15), a justice of the peace’s order (Section 16), the return of a person who has broken a community treatment order (Section 33.4), and the return of an involuntary patient who has left hospital (Section 28). Each apprehension is logged in the police records system with the neighbourhood where it happened, and the published data is extracted from that system.

Several features of this process shape what the data can and cannot tell us. The data records apprehensions, not people: someone detained five times appears five times, and there is no person identifier. It records where an apprehension *happened*, not where the person lives. Records of people aged 17 and under are removed before publication, so the data covers adults only. Neighbourhood is missing (“NSA”) for 1,438 apprehensions, which we keep for citywide counts but exclude from neighbourhood analysis. The data also omits everything that did not end in an apprehension: crisis calls resolved on scene, calls diverted to the Community Crisis Service, and voluntary visits to hospital. An apprehension therefore measures a particular outcome of a police encounter, not mental health need.

The neighbourhood characteristics come from the 2021 Census long-form questionnaire, a 25 per cent sample, aggregated by the City to its neighbourhoods. They describe residents at one point in time, which we treat as fixed over the twelve years of apprehension data.

In the arrest data, race is the officer’s *perception* of the person’s race, recorded at the time of arrest, not the person’s own identity. The behaviour flags, including “mental instability or possibly suicidal”, are also officers’ judgements. To compare groups, we built a population benchmark from the 2021 Census by combining census categories to match the police ones; for example, East and Southeast Asian combines Chinese, Filipino, Southeast Asian, Korean and Japanese, and White is approximated by residents who are neither a visible minority nor Indigenous.

2.3 Apprehensions over time and by authority

Figure 1 shows every month of the series. Apprehensions rose by about 81 per cent from 7,387 in 2014 to a peak of 13,350 in 2021, dipped after the Community Crisis Service began in March 2022, and have since returned to about 12,700 a year. Men account for most apprehensions, but women make up 44 per cent of them, and the most common age group is 25 to 34.

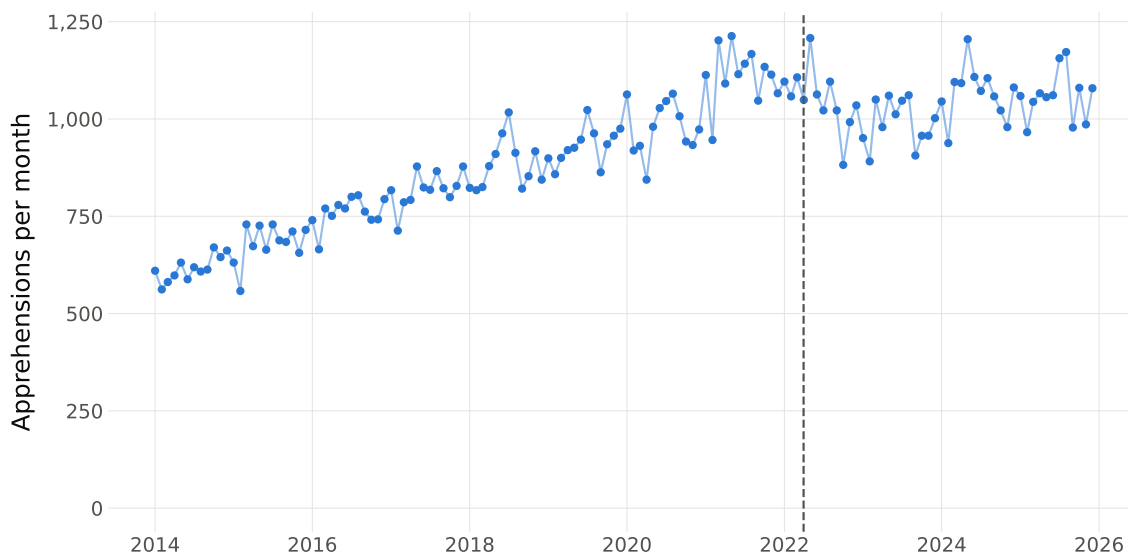


Figure 1: Mental Health Act apprehensions in Toronto rose through 2021 and have been roughly flat since. Each point is one month’s total; the dashed line marks the launch of the Toronto Community Crisis Service pilots in March 2022.

Table 1 shows that 79 per cent of apprehensions rest on an officer’s own judgement under Section 17, a share that rose from 78 per cent in 2014 to 82 per cent in 2025. In four cases in five, then, no physician or court was involved before police detained the person.

Table 1: Four in five apprehensions in 2014–2025 were made under Section 17, on the officer’s own judgement. The other authorities carry out a decision by a physician, a justice of the peace or a hospital.

Authority	Who decides	Apprehensions	Share
Section 17	Police officer, on scene	104,164	79.3%
Section 15 (Form 1)	Physician	10,703	8.2%
Section 16 (Form 2)	Justice of the peace	9,074	6.9%
Section 33.4 (Form 47)	Physician, community treatment order	5,777	4.4%
Section 28 (Form 9)	Hospital, patient absent without leave	1,607	1.2%

2.4 Apprehensions by neighbourhood

Because larger neighbourhoods have more apprehensions simply because more people live there, we compare rates: the average number of apprehensions per year per 1,000 residents. The median neighbourhood has 3.5. Figure 2 shows that the highest rates are in the downtown core, with further pockets in the northwest and east. Rates range from 1.2 in Steeles to 17.1 in University.

The downtown figures need care. Apprehensions are recorded where they happen, but rates divide by people who live there. Downtown neighbourhoods contain hospitals, shelters, transit hubs and large daytime populations: University, the highest rate, has only 6,435 residents. Residential population is a poor denominator for such places (Andresen 2011), so we define a downtown core of 13 neighbourhoods, those whose centre lies east of Bathurst Street, west of the Don River and south of Bloor Street, and check every result without them.

2.5 Neighbourhood characteristics

Table 2 summarizes the neighbourhood characteristics used in the model. Neighbourhoods vary widely: the share of households that rent ranges from under 10 per cent to almost 90 per cent, and the Indigenous share of residents, while small everywhere, varies more than seventy-fold. 33 neighbourhoods are designated Neighbourhood Improvement Areas, the City’s label for neighbourhoods below its equity benchmark (City of Toronto 2014).

Figure 3 plots every neighbourhood’s apprehension rate against each characteristic in the model. Rates rise with renter share, low-income share and Indigenous share, and rise only slightly with Black share. The downtown neighbourhoods, in orange, sit at the top of each panel; outside them the associations with renting and Indigenous share remain, while the one with low income is much weaker. These characteristics are correlated with one another, so the model in Section 3 considers them together.

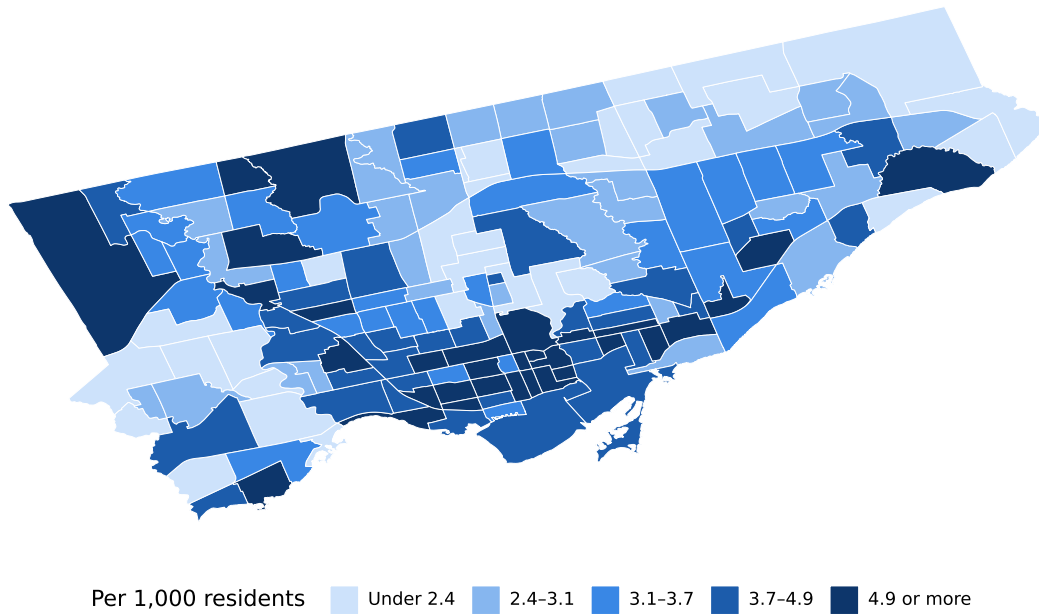


Figure 2: Apprehension rates are highest in the downtown core, with further high-rate areas in the northwest and east. Each of the 158 neighbourhoods is shaded by its average annual apprehensions per 1,000 residents in 2014–2025, grouped into fifths.

Table 2: Toronto’s 158 neighbourhoods differ widely in renting, income and population composition. Values are the median and range across neighbourhoods, from the 2021 Census, alongside the average annual apprehension rate for 2014–2025.

Measure	Median	Range
Apprehensions per 1,000 residents per year	3.5	1.2 – 17.1
Population	16,812	6,260 – 33,300
Households that rent (%)	46	8 – 89
Residents in low income (%)	12.2	4.3 – 29.0
Indigenous residents (%)	0.8	0.0 – 3.0
Black residents (%)	6.8	0.7 – 37.9
Visible minority residents (%)	51	13 – 96
Median household income (\$)	84,500	57,200 – 222,000

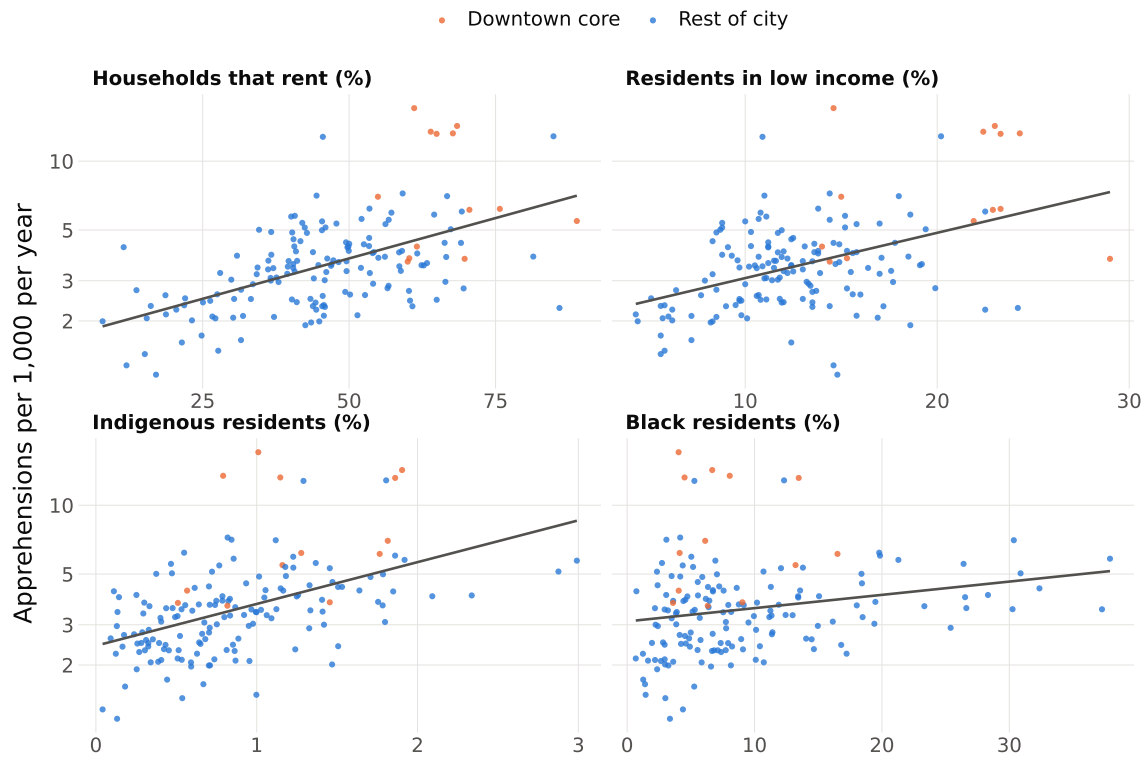


Figure 3: Apprehension rates rise with the share of households that rent and the share of Indigenous residents. Each point is one neighbourhood; orange points are the downtown core. The vertical axis is on a log scale, and grey lines are least-squares fits on that scale.

2.6 Arrests and strip searches by race

The arrest data contains 65,276 records for 37,347 people. Figure 4 compares, for each perceived-race group, the number of different people arrested at least once in 2020 and 2021 with the number of residents in that group. Black people were arrested at 38.6 per 1,000 residents and Indigenous people at 35.6, against 12.5 for White people. This is consistent with earlier evidence of disproportionate police contact with Black Torontonians (Wortley and Owusu-Bempah 2011; Meng 2017; Ontario Human Rights Commission 2020). People arrested include non-residents, and the benchmark counts residents only, so these ratios are approximate.

Until October 2020, Toronto police strip searched a large share of the people they arrested: 27 per cent of arrests from January to September 2020. Strip searches are lawful only when there are specific grounds for one in the circumstances of an arrest (Supreme Court of Canada 2001), and a provincial review had found Toronto's rate far above other Ontario services (Office of

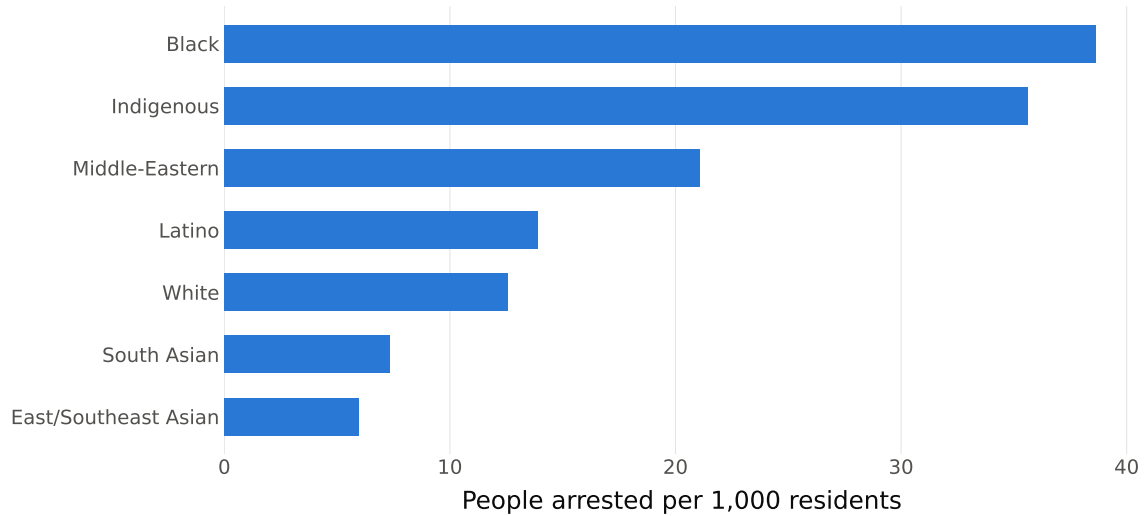


Figure 4: Black and Indigenous people were arrested at about three times the White rate in 2020–2021, relative to their share of Toronto’s population. Bars show the number of different people arrested at least once per 1,000 residents of the same perceived-race group.

the Independent Police Review Director 2019). A new procedure took effect in October 2020, and by the last quarter of 2021 only 1 per cent of arrests involved a strip search. Figure 5 shows strip search rates among people who were booked, the stage at which searches happen, before and after the change. Before it, more than half of booked Indigenous, Black and White people were strip searched, against about a third of other groups. The rates for Black and White people were almost the same, so the large Black–White difference in this data arises at arrest rather than at the search.

Officers flagged 3.3 per cent of arrests as involving “mental instability or possibly suicidal” behaviour. This flag is the arrest data’s link to crisis policing, and Section 4 models how it relates to strip searches.

2.7 Ethics

Both datasets describe people at difficult moments, and some of them more than once. The published data contains no names, exact locations or dates of birth; apprehension records of young people are withheld, and arrest records give only quarters and police divisions. We report only aggregates. Two ethical points shape how the results should be read. Race in the arrest data is an officer’s perception, so it measures how police see people, not how people identify. And the apprehension analysis describes neighbourhoods, not individuals: a higher rate where

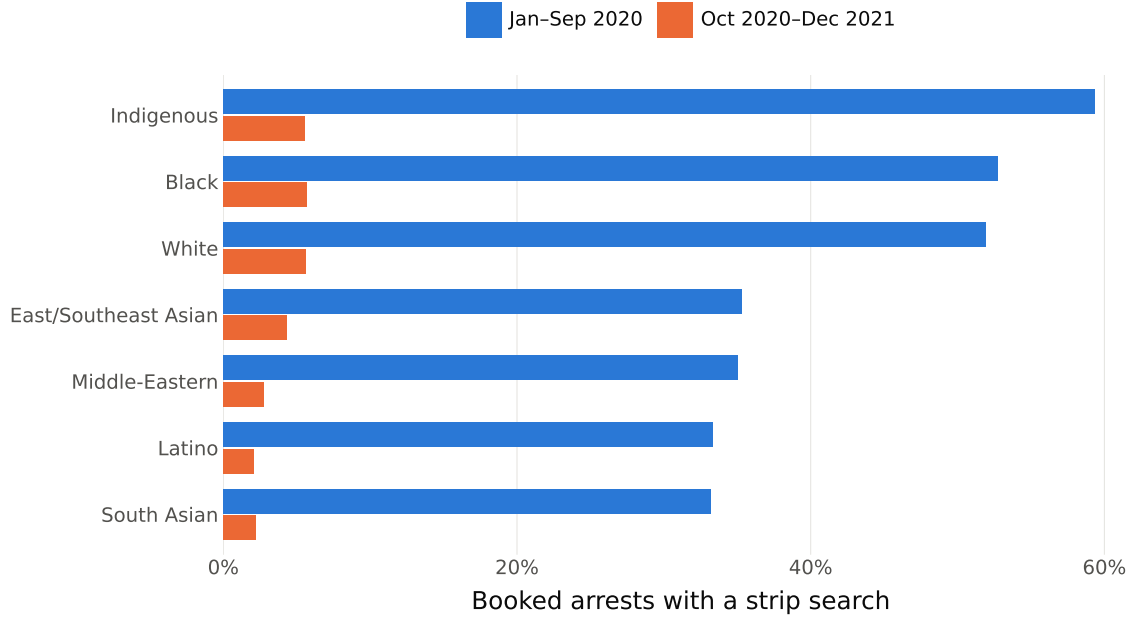


Figure 5: Before the October 2020 procedure change, more than half of booked Indigenous, Black and White people were strip searched; afterwards rates fell below 6 per cent for every group. Bars show the share of booked arrests that included a strip search.

more Indigenous people live does not show that Indigenous residents are apprehended more, and we do not claim that it does.

3 Model

3.1 Apprehension rates

We model the number of apprehensions y_{it} in neighbourhood i in year t as negative binomial, with the neighbourhood's population N_i as exposure:

$$y_{it} \sim \text{NegativeBinomial}(\mu_{it}, \alpha)$$

$$\log \mu_{it} = \log N_i + \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Renter}_i + \beta_2 \text{LowIncome}_i + \beta_3 \text{Indigenous}_i + \beta_4 \text{Black}_i + \beta_5 \text{NIA}_i + \gamma_t$$

where the four shares are standardized to mean zero and standard deviation one across neighbourhoods, NIA indicates a Neighbourhood Improvement Area, and γ_t are year effects.

Each $\exp(\beta_k)$ is a rate ratio: the multiplicative change in the apprehension rate for a one-standard-deviation increase in that characteristic, holding the others and the year fixed.

Three choices follow from the data. Counts are far more variable than a Poisson model allows (the neighbourhood-year mean is 69 and the variance 2,582), so we use the negative binomial, whose dispersion parameter α is estimated at 0.15. Year effects absorb citywide changes, including the 2021 peak and the launch of the Community Crisis Service, so the β_k compare neighbourhoods within the same year. And because each neighbourhood appears twelve times, standard errors are clustered by neighbourhood. Median household income is left out because it is strongly correlated with low-income share ($r = -0.70$); with both in the model, variance inflation factors stay below 2.5, and without it they stay near 2. The model is fitted with statsmodels (Seabold and Perktold 2010) on 1,896 neighbourhood-years.

We fit the model four times: on all apprehensions; excluding the 13 downtown neighbourhoods; on Section 17 apprehensions only; and on the other authorities only. The last two compare apprehensions where the officer decided with those where a physician or court did. If officers' discretion is shaped by the character of places (Morabito 2007), Section 17 should track neighbourhood characteristics more closely.

Before fitting the model to real data, we fitted it to simulated data in which the true effects are known. It recovered them (Section B).

3.2 Strip searches

For the arrest data we fit a logistic regression of whether a booked person was strip searched, among arrests from January to September 2020, before the procedure change:

$$\text{logit Pr}(\text{Strip}_j = 1) = \delta_0 + \delta_1 \text{Flag}_j + \sum_g \theta_g \text{Race}_{jg} + \sum_g \lambda_g (\text{Flag}_j \times \text{Race}_{jg}) + \mathbf{x}'_j \boldsymbol{\eta}$$

where Flag_j indicates that the officer recorded mental instability, race groups are Black, Indigenous and other groups (East and Southeast Asian, South Asian, Middle-Eastern and Latino combined) with White as the reference, and $\mathbf{x}_j$ holds offence category, age group and sex. The interaction terms λ_g test whether the flag's association with strip searching differs by group. Standard errors are clustered by person because some people were arrested several times.

Table 3: Renter share and Indigenous share are associated with higher apprehension rates in every specification. Rate ratios per one-standard-deviation increase (per 1 for Improvement Area status), with 95% confidence intervals, from negative binomial models with population exposure, year effects and standard errors clustered by neighbourhood.

	All	Excl. downtown	Section 17	Other types
Households that rent	1.16 (1.05–1.28)	1.17 (1.08–1.26)	1.16 (1.07–1.26)	1.14 (0.94–1.38)
Residents in low income	1.12 (1.01–1.25)	0.99 (0.91–1.07)	1.09 (0.99–1.20)	1.23 (1.03–1.47)
Indigenous residents	1.21 (1.13–1.28)	1.17 (1.12–1.23)	1.18 (1.12–1.24)	1.33 (1.17–1.52)
Black residents	1.02 (0.95–1.10)	1.03 (0.97–1.11)	1.03 (0.96–1.10)	1.03 (0.89–1.18)
Improvement Area	0.93 (0.77–1.13)	1.09 (0.93–1.28)	0.95 (0.80–1.14)	0.82 (0.59–1.14)
Neighbourhood-years	1,896	1,740	1,896	1,896
Dispersion (alpha)	0.15	0.12	0.12	0.51

4 Results

4.1 Neighbourhood characteristics and apprehension rates

Table 3 and Figure 6 report the rate ratios. Across all neighbourhoods, a one-standard-deviation increase in renter share is associated with a rate ratio of 1.16 (95% CI 1.05–1.28), and in Indigenous share 1.21 (95% CI 1.13–1.28). Low-income share has a smaller association, 1.12 (95% CI 1.01–1.25). Black share, 1.02 (95% CI 0.95–1.10), and Improvement Area status, 0.93 (95% CI 0.77–1.13), are not distinguishable from no association.

Excluding the downtown core leaves the renter and Indigenous associations essentially unchanged, 1.17 and 1.17, but removes the low-income association, 0.99 (95% CI 0.91–1.07). The link between poverty and apprehensions in the full model therefore comes from the downtown core, where residential rates are least reliable.

Section 17 apprehensions follow almost the same pattern as all apprehensions. They are not more closely tied to neighbourhood characteristics than apprehensions authorized by others; if anything, the other authorities track low income, 1.23, and Indigenous share, 1.33, more strongly, though with wider intervals.

4.2 Mental health flags and strip searches

Among booked arrests before the procedure change, a mental-instability flag is associated with much higher odds of a strip search: an odds ratio of 2.74 (95% CI 2.11–3.56) for White people, after adjusting for offence, age and sex. For Black people the association is larger, with an interaction odds ratio of 1.75 (95% CI 1.11–2.74). Figure 7 converts the model to probabilities. Without a flag, booked Black and White people had similar predicted probabilities of a strip search, 49 per cent and 51 per cent. With a flag, the probability rose to 71 per cent for White

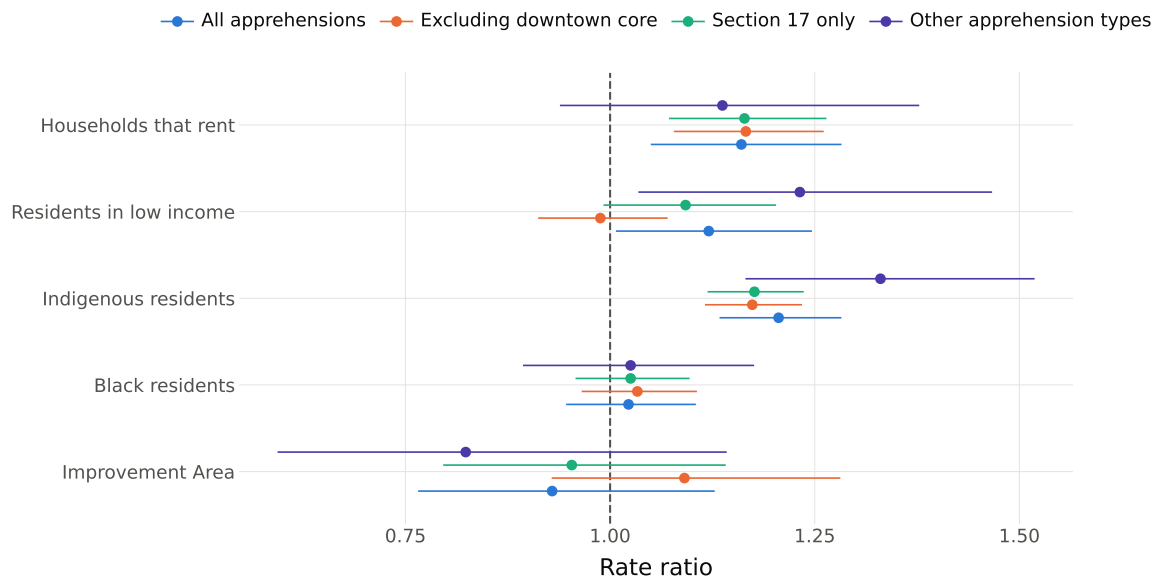


Figure 6: The associations with renter share and Indigenous share hold across specifications, while the low-income association disappears without the downtown core. Points are rate ratios and lines are 95% confidence intervals; values above 1 mean higher apprehension rates.

people and 79 per cent for Black people. The estimate for Indigenous people rests on 29 flagged arrests and is too uncertain to interpret. Full estimates are in Section C.

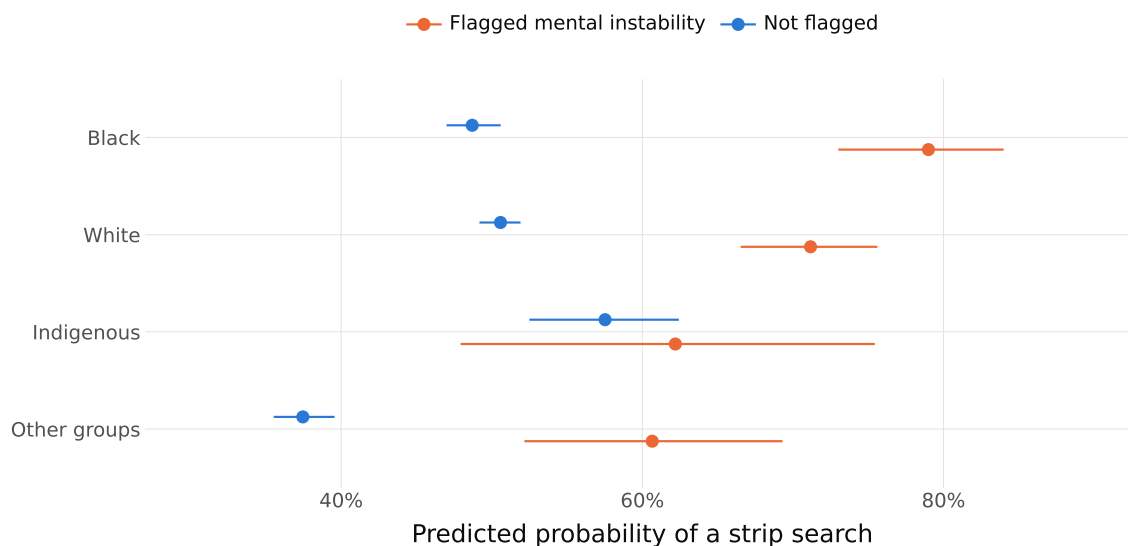


Figure 7: A mental-instability flag raised the predicted probability of a strip search for every group, most of all for Black people. Average predicted probabilities among booked arrests in January–September 2020, adjusted for offence, age and sex; lines are 95% intervals from 2,000 draws of the model coefficients.

5 Discussion

5.1 Crisis policing follows renting and Indigenous presence

The clearest result is that apprehensions are more frequent where more households rent and more Indigenous people live, and that this holds outside the downtown core. Renting is likely a marker of several things the census does not measure directly: residential instability, rooming houses and supportive housing, and fewer private resources to manage a crisis without calling 9-1-1. Research in Toronto has found that homeless people with mental illness have more police interactions than those who are housed (Kouyoumdjian et al. 2019), and research in England has found compulsory psychiatric admission more likely in deprived and more ethnically diverse small areas (Weich et al. 2017). Our results fit both. The association with Indigenous share is consistent with the over-representation of Indigenous people in police contact more broadly, although with neighbourhood data we cannot say whether Indigenous residents themselves are apprehended more.

Two expected associations were weak. Neighbourhood poverty mattered only because of the downtown core, and the City’s designation of disadvantaged neighbourhoods added nothing once renting and Indigenous share were in the model. Crisis policing therefore follows specific features of neighbourhoods rather than a general measure of disadvantage. Black population

share also had little association at the neighbourhood level. This does not contradict research showing that Black people are more likely to reach psychiatric care through police (Anderson et al. 2014): three of the five lowest-rate neighbourhoods are over 90 per cent visible minority, and neighbourhood composition is a poor guide to who is detained.

5.2 Officer discretion is not more place-bound

We expected officer-initiated apprehensions to track neighbourhood characteristics more closely than those authorized by physicians or courts. They did not. One explanation is that the decision that matters is not the officer's but the call: officers can only apprehend people they are called to, and calls depend on who is present, who is watching and who has other options. The other authorities, which often involve people already known to mental health services, may be even more concentrated in places with supportive housing and treatment programs.

5.3 Race and crisis at arrest

The arrest data shows that the largest racial disparity is in who is arrested at all. Black and Indigenous people were arrested at about three times the White rate, a gap similar to the Ontario Human Rights Commission's finding for 2013–2017 (Ontario Human Rights Commission 2020). Once booked, Black and White people were strip searched at almost the same rate, and searches found items at similar rates for every group (Section D), which is consistent with, but does not prove, equal search standards (Knowles et al. 2001; Simoiu et al. 2017). The finding that bears most directly on crisis policing is that a mental-instability flag made a strip search far more likely, and more so for Black people. People in apparent crisis were subjected to the most intrusive search police conduct, which is consistent with evidence that apparent mental illness makes police encounters more coercive (Kesic et al. 2013).

5.4 The Community Crisis Service

Apprehensions fell after the Community Crisis Service began in 2022 and then partly recovered. With year effects absorbing this change, our models say nothing about whether the service reduced apprehensions. The service received about 4,500 eligible 9-1-1 calls in 2025, compared with roughly 12,700 apprehensions (City of Toronto 2026a), so its reach is still limited. Because its pilots started in specific areas before expanding, a comparison of pilot and non-pilot neighbourhoods before and after 2022, of the kind used to evaluate Denver's similar program (Dee and Pyne 2022), could estimate its effect.

5.5 Weaknesses and next steps

The analysis has several limitations. It is ecological: neighbourhood associations do not describe individuals. The residential denominator distorts rates in the downtown core, and although our results hold without it, high-traffic places outside downtown, such as the area around the Centre for Addiction and Mental Health in West Queen West, are affected too. An ambient-population denominator would be better (Andresen 2011). Census characteristics are fixed at 2021, while apprehensions span twelve years. The data contains no person identifier, so a small number of people detained repeatedly may weigh heavily in some neighbourhoods. The arrest data covers only 2020 and 2021, years shaped by the pandemic, relies on officers' perceptions of race and behaviour, and has small numbers of flagged people in some groups.

Three extensions would address these. Linking apprehensions to health records, as Ontario studies of involuntary admission have done (Lebenbaum et al. 2018), would show who is detained and what happens next. A pilot-area comparison could evaluate the Community Crisis Service. And publication of apprehension data with the person's race, as Toronto now does for arrests, would allow the individual-level analysis that the neighbourhood data cannot support.

A Data cleaning

- **Period.** We keep apprehensions that occurred from 2014 to the last complete calendar year, 2025, dropping 13 records with earlier occurrence dates and the partial current year.
- **Missing codes.** “NSA” and “Not Recorded” values are treated as missing.
- **Repeated incidents.** Some incidents involve more than one person and share an incident number. All rows are kept because each is a separate apprehension, and there is no person identifier with which to identify duplicates.
- **Neighbourhood panel.** Every neighbourhood-year appears, with zeros where there were no apprehensions.
- **Downtown core.** We define it as neighbourhoods whose centroid lies east of Bathurst Street (longitude -79.4065), west of the Don River (-79.356) and south of Bloor Street (latitude 43.6705), approximating the City’s Downtown Plan area.
- **Arrest data.** Labels that changed between 2020 and 2021 (offence categories, age groups, youth status) are combined into one scheme. Strip searches without a recorded booking are treated as booked, following the source documentation. Our cleaned data reproduces the Toronto Police Service’s published strip search rate of 22.2 per cent for 2020 (Toronto Police Service 2022).
- **Tests.** Every cleaned and simulated table is checked by automated tests for schema, valid values, internal consistency and agreement with the raw data.

B Model checks

B.1 Recovery of simulated effects

We simulated neighbourhood-year counts in which the log apprehension rate rises by 0.015 per percentage point of renter households and falls by 0.6 per unit of log median income, with overdispersion $\alpha = 0.2$. Fitting the same model specification to the simulated data recovers these values (Table 4).

Table 4: The negative binomial specification recovers the effects built into the simulated data. True values are those used to simulate; estimates and 95% confidence intervals are from fitting the model to the simulation.

Parameter	True value	Estimate	95% CI
Renter share (per point)	0.015	0.015	0.014 to 0.017
Log median income	-0.600	-0.552	-0.62 to -0.48
Dispersion (alpha)	0.200	0.188	

B.2 Fit to observed counts

Figure 8 compares the main model's fitted counts with the observed counts for every neighbourhood-year. Points lie close to the diagonal across the range, with the largest residuals in a few downtown neighbourhoods.

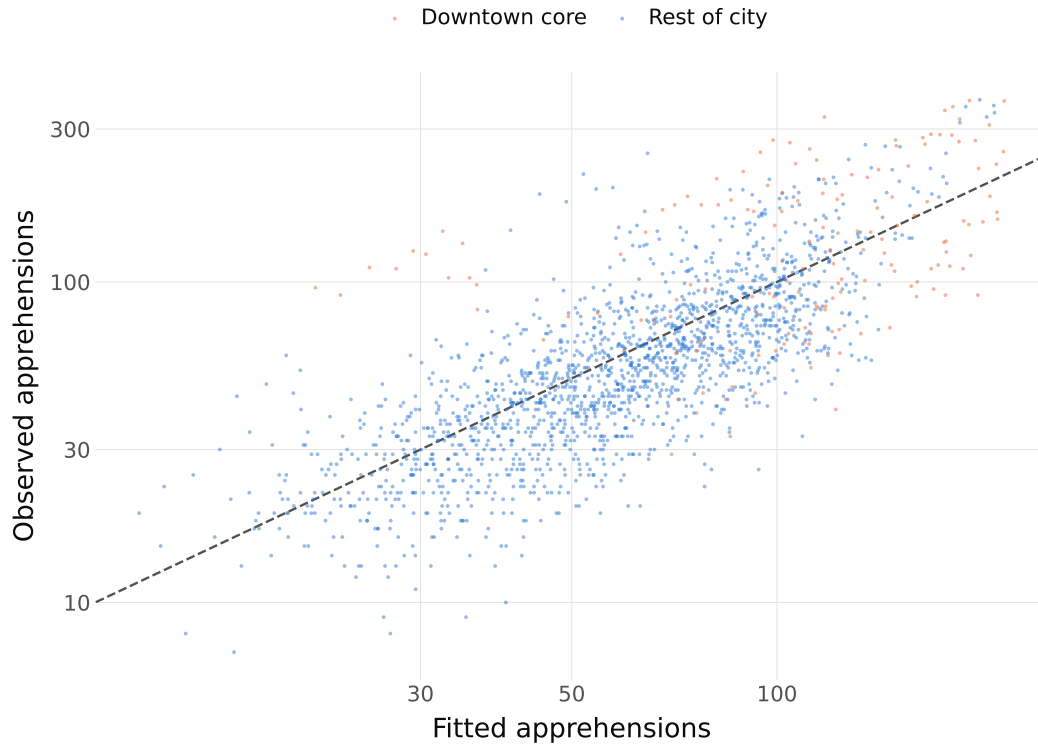


Figure 8: The main model's fitted counts track the observed counts across all 1,896 neighbourhood-years. Each point is one neighbourhood in one year; orange points are the downtown core; the dashed line marks perfect agreement. Both axes are on a log scale.

C Strip search model

Table 5: A mental-instability flag nearly triples the odds of a strip search, and the increase is larger for Black people. Odds ratios with 95% confidence intervals from a logistic regression of strip searching among booked arrests in January–September 2020, adjusted for offence category, age group and sex, with standard errors clustered by person. White people are the reference group.

Term	Odds ratio	95% CI low	95% CI high	p-value
Black	0.92	0.82	1.02	0.110
Indigenous	1.38	1.09	1.76	0.008
Other groups	0.53	0.47	0.60	0.000
Mental-instability flag	2.74	2.11	3.56	0.000
Flag $\times$ Black	1.75	1.11	2.74	0.015
Flag $\times$ Indigenous	0.46	0.20	1.02	0.056
Flag $\times$ Other groups	1.10	0.67	1.80	0.706

D Disparities at each stage of contact

Table 6 follows each perceived-race group from the population through arrest, booking and strip search before the October 2020 procedure change, and reports how often strip searches found items. The largest departure from population shares is at arrest. Booking and strip search rates for Black and White people are similar, and the share of strip searches that found items is similar for every group.

Table 6: The largest racial disparity is at arrest; booking, strip search and search outcomes differ much less between Black and White people. Population share is from the 2021 Census; arrest share counts different people arrested in 2020–2021; booking and strip search rates are for January–September 2020; items found is the share of all strip searches in 2020–2021 that found items.

Perceived race	Population	People arrested	Booked	Strip searched	Items found
White	45%	42%	56%	52%	38%
East/Southeast Asian	22%	10%	52%	35%	34%
South Asian	15%	8%	54%	33%	35%
Black	10%	28%	59%	53%	38%
Middle-Eastern	4%	7%	50%	35%	37%
Latino	3%	4%	60%	33%	36%
Indigenous	1%	2%	61%	59%	38%

References

- Alexander, Rohan. 2023. *Telling Stories with Data*. Chapman and Hall/CRC. <https://tellingstorieswithdata.com/>.
- Allaire, J. J., Charles Teague, Carlos Scheidegger, Yihui Xie, and Christophe Dervieux. 2022. *Quarto*. <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.5960048>.
- Anderson, Kelly K., Nina Flora, Suzanne Archie, Craig Morgan, and Kwame McKenzie. 2014. "A Meta-Analysis of Ethnic Differences in Pathways to Care at the First Episode of Psychosis." *Acta Psychiatrica Scandinavica* 130: 257–68. <https://doi.org/10.1111/acps.12254>.
- Andresen, Martin A. 2011. "The Ambient Population and Crime Analysis." *The Professional Geographer* 63 (2): 193–212.
- Boyce, Jillian, Cristine Rotenberg, and Maisie Karam. 2015. "Mental Health and Contact with Police in Canada, 2012." *Juristat*. <https://www150.statcan.gc.ca/n1/pub/85-002-x/2015001/article/14176-eng.htm>.
- City of Toronto. 2014. *TSNS 2020 Neighbourhood Equity Index: Methodological Documentation*. City of Toronto. <https://www.toronto.ca/wp-content/uploads/2017/11/97eb-TSNS-2020-NEI-equity-index-methodology-research-report-backgroundfile-67350.pdf>.
- City of Toronto. 2023. *Toronto Community Crisis Service: One-Year Outcome Evaluation Report*. City of Toronto. <https://www.toronto.ca/wp-content/uploads/2023/10/97b8-Toronto-Community-Crisis-Service-1-Year-Outcome-Evaluation-Report.pdf>.
- City of Toronto. 2026a. *Advancing the Toronto Community Crisis Service*. Report for action. City of Toronto. <https://www.toronto.ca/legdocs/mmis/2026/ex/bgrd/backgroundfile-289503.pdf>.
- City of Toronto. 2026b. *Neighbourhood Profiles*. <https://open.toronto.ca/dataset/neighbourhood-profiles/>.
- City of Toronto. 2026c. *Neighbourhoods*. <https://open.toronto.ca/dataset/neighbourhoods/>.
- City of Toronto. 2026d. *Open Data Toronto*. <https://open.toronto.ca/>.
- Dee, Thomas S., and Jaymes Pyne. 2022. "A Community Response Approach to Mental Health and Substance Abuse Crises Reduced Crime." *Science Advances* 8 (23): eabm2106. <https://doi.org/10.1126/sciadv.abm2106>.

- Gillies, Sean et al. 2025. *Shapely: Manipulation and Analysis of Geometric Objects*. <https://shapely.readthedocs.io/>.
- Government of Ontario. 1990. *Mental Health Act, R.S.O. 1990, c. M.7*. <https://www.ontario.ca/laws/statute/90m07>.
- Harris, Charles R., K. Jarrod Millman, Stéfan J. van der Walt, et al. 2020. “Array Programming with NumPy.” *Nature* 585: 357–62. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41586-020-2649-2>.
- Iacobucci, Frank. 2014. *Police Encounters with People in Crisis: An Independent Review Conducted by the Honourable Frank Iacobucci for Chief of Police William Blair, Toronto Police Service*. Independent review. Toronto Police Service.
- Iannone, Richard, and Michael Chow. 2026. *Great Tables: Make Awesome Display Tables Using Python*. <https://posit-dev.github.io/great-tables/>.
- Jordahl, Kelsey et al. 2026. *GeoPandas: Python Tools for Geographic Data*. <https://geopandas.org/>.
- Kesic, Dragana, Stuart D. M. Thomas, and James R. P. Ogloff. 2013. “Use of Nonfatal Force on and by Persons with Apparent Mental Disorder in Encounters with Police.” *Criminal Justice and Behavior* 40 (3): 321–37.
- Kibirige, Hassan et al. 2026. *Plotnine: A Grammar of Graphics for Python*. <https://plotnine.org/>.
- Knowles, John, Nicola Persico, and Petra Todd. 2001. “Racial Bias in Motor Vehicle Searches: Theory and Evidence.” *Journal of Political Economy* 109 (1): 203–29. <https://doi.org/10.1086/318603>.
- Kouyoumdjian, Fiona G., Ri Wang, Cilia Mejia-Lancheros, et al. 2019. “Interactions Between Police and Persons Who Experience Homelessness and Mental Illness in Toronto, Canada: Findings from a Prospective Study.” *The Canadian Journal of Psychiatry* 64 (10): 718–25. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0706743719861386>.
- Krekel, Holger et al. 2026. *Pytest*. <https://pytest.org/>.
- Lebenbaum, Michael, Maria Chiu, Simone Vigod, and Paul Kurdyak. 2018. “Prevalence and Predictors of Involuntary Psychiatric Hospital Admissions in Ontario, Canada: A Population-Based Linked Administrative Database Study.” *BJPsych Open* 4 (2): 31–38.
- Livingston, James D. 2016. “Contact Between Police and People with Mental Disorders: A Review of Rates.” *Psychiatric Services* 67 (8): 850–57. <https://doi.org/10.1176/appi.ps>.

201500312.

- McKinney, Wes. 2010. “Data Structures for Statistical Computing in Python.” *Proceedings of the 9th Python in Science Conference*, 56–61. <https://doi.org/10.25080/Majora-92bf1922-00a>.
- Meng, Yunliang. 2017. “Profiling Minorities: Police Stop and Search Practices in Toronto, Canada.” *Human Geographies* 11 (1): 5–23. <https://doi.org/10.5719/hgeo.2017.111.1>.
- Morabito, Melissa Schaefer. 2007. “Horizons of Context: Understanding the Police Decision to Arrest People with Mental Illness.” *Psychiatric Services* 58 (12): 1582–87. <https://doi.org/10.1176/ps.2007.58.12.1582>.
- Office of the Independent Police Review Director. 2019. *Breaking the Golden Rule: A Review of Police Strip Searches in Ontario*. Office of the Independent Police Review Director.
- Ontario Human Rights Commission. 2020. *A Disparate Impact: Second Interim Report on the Inquiry into Racial Profiling and Racial Discrimination of Black Persons by the Toronto Police Service*. Ontario Human Rights Commission. <https://www.ohrc.on.ca/en/disparate-impact-second-interim-report-inquiry-racial-profiling-and-racial-discrimination-black>.
- Python Software Foundation. 2025. *Python: A Programming Language*. <https://www.python.org/>.
- Seabold, Skipper, and Josef Perktold. 2010. “Statsmodels: Econometric and Statistical Modeling with Python.” *Proceedings of the 9th Python in Science Conference*, 92–96. <https://doi.org/10.25080/Majora-92bf1922-011>.
- Simoiu, Camelia, Sam Corbett-Davies, and Sharad Goel. 2017. “The Problem of Infra-Marginality in Outcome Tests for Discrimination.” *The Annals of Applied Statistics* 11 (3): 1193–216.
- Supreme Court of Canada. 2001. *R v Golden, 2001 SCC 83, [2001] 3 SCR 679*. <https://www.canlii.org/en/ca/scc/doc/2001/2001scc83/2001scc83.html>.
- Toronto Police Service. 2022. *Race & Identity Based Data Collection Strategy: Understanding Use of Force & Strip Searches in 2020, Detailed Report*. Toronto Police Service. <https://www.tps.ca/race-identity-based-data-collection/>.
- Toronto Police Service. 2026a. *Mental Health Act Apprehensions*. <https://open.toronto.ca/dataset/mental-health-apprehensions/>.
- Toronto Police Service. 2026b. *Race & Identity Based Data Collection: Arrests and Strip*

Searches. https://services.arcgis.com/S9th0jAJ7bqgIRjw/ArcGIS/rest/services/RBDC_ARR_TBL_001/FeatureServer.

Vink, Ritchie et al. 2026. *Polars: Blazingly Fast DataFrames in Rust, Python, Node.js, R and SQL.* <https://pola.rs/>.

Weich, Scott, Orla McBride, Liz Twigg, et al. 2017. “Variation in Compulsory Psychiatric Inpatient Admission in England: A Cross-Classified, Multilevel Analysis.” *The Lancet Psychiatry* 4 (8): 619–26.

Wortley, Scot, and Akwasi Owusu-Bempah. 2011. “The Usual Suspects: Police Stop and Search Practices in Canada.” *Policing and Society* 21: 395–407. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10439463.2011.610198>.